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MEMO · POINT OF VIEW

WHERE GENERATIVE TOOLS ACTUALLY ENTER A POST PIPELINE

A note for producers deciding whether to bring generative tooling onto a show this year.

AUSTIN PATEREK · 07.30.26

The decision in front of you

You have been asked whether generative tools belong on your next project. The question usually arrives with a budget attached and a vendor deck already circulating, and it can be difficult to decide who is best equipped or empowered to answer.

I want to give you a more useful frame than yes or no. The question is not whether generative tools work. It is where in the pipeline they work, what they cost you when they land in the wrong place, and what you owe the people whose work they touch. There is also a question nobody is asking yet, and I will come back to it: what these tools could give back.

I am writing this as a fellow creator, a picture editor and producer. Fourteen years of cutting and running post on streaming and linear series, most recently as editor for the series *Baylen Out Loud*. I also write this as an anthropologist by training, with a master's in visual anthropology and dissertation fieldwork in workplace ethnography. I care deeply for my colleagues and for workers everywhere navigating this monumental transition in our workforce, economy, and society. Take what follows as a practitioner's map, not a policy position.

What is actually happening on shows right now

Three things, mostly.

The first is invisible and already ubiquitous. Cleanup, rotoscoping, upres, denoise, audio isolation, transcription. Machine-learning tooling has been inside these processes for years and nobody calls it AI because nobody needs to. It works, it saves real hours, and it has quietly changed what a small post team can take on.

The second is exploratory. Generated boards, temp imagery, style frames, scratch elements to hold a place in a cut while something real gets made: ideation and iteration looping in search of something that excites creatives and audiences. This is where most of the current experimentation actually lives, whatever the press says.

The third is the one everyone argues about, and it is the smallest by volume: generated material intended for final delivery.

The gap between the second category and the third is where most bad decisions get made, because a tool that is genuinely excellent at the first two gets sold as though it is ready for the third.

Where it genuinely changes the work

Fix it in pre! The most defensible current use is compressing the distance between an idea and something you can look at. A director describing a sequence and a director showing you a rough version of that sequence are two very different meetings. Getting to the second meeting faster is worth real money, and it is worth it precisely because the output is disposable.

When we are work-for-hire on someone else's project, we are all trying to get to the answer for one question posed to creators, stakeholders, owners, and clients: what is it that you want? No matter your department or personal goals, we must answer that question. And more often than not the answer is: "I don't know, but I'll know it when I see it." I have heard this sentence more times than I care to recall. It is a frustration to hear, but understandable coming from many individuals who are trained and responsible for scopes outside imagination and creation. Where generative work offers us the most leverage is in presenting the "see it" moment faster, and leaving more budget intact for production and post. It gets us answers we need today without the frustration of taking a project all the way to fully cut before key decisions can be made.

Holding a place honestly. Temp material has always been a lie we agree to tell each other. Generative temp is a better lie in one specific way: it can be closer to intent, so notes come back about the thing you are actually making rather than about the placeholder. It is a worse lie in another way, which I will get to.

Volume work with a clear spec. Where the deliverable is defined, repetitive, and judged against a checklist rather than against taste, these tools hold up. The first pass no longer needs a person. The sign-off still does.

Where it does not, and what it costs to find out

Finishing. Not because the images are bad, though often they are (slop is called slop for a reason). Because finishing is where accountability lives. Every frame that reaches air has to be defensible to standards and practices, to legal, and to whoever signed the talent agreement. I have witnessed producers on low-budget films assume they could just "deepfake" a lead actor's head onto a ballerina double, as the professional dancer spun with speed and grace. I have then seen those producers have to hire a VFX consultant, find out they would need to bring that consultant on as a producer, and redo the entire VFX pass for the dancing scene. I have not yet seen a generative workflow that survives that chain without someone rebuilding the asset conventionally anyway, which means you paid twice. Perhaps this will change, but for now, we, the film and television makers, cannot rely on hope. We must choose shrewdly where optimization can live.

Anything requiring consistency across a season. Generated material drifts. It drifts between sessions, between operators, and between tool versions. A show is a promise of consistency, and it can be a trap to assume that can be bought with a few tokens on a model. We must rely upon our department heads and crew, who have spent their careers delivering consistency, to understand where AI optimization can help them, while not presuming AI could deliver exactly the same thing on its own.

The temp trap. This is the failure I would warn a producer about first, and it is not technical. When temp material is close to intent, executives stop reading it as temp. The note comes back approving something nobody has costed, scheduled, or cleared. You have not saved time. You have moved the argument later, into a week where it is more expensive to lose.

The honest version of the second category, then, comes with a process requirement: if you use generated temp, you have to be aggressive about labeling it and disciplined about who sees it. That is a producing problem, not a tooling problem, and no vendor will solve it for you.

The part that is not a workflow question

Everything above treats this as a craft and scheduling problem. It is also a jobs problem, and a piece like this is dishonest if it treats that as an aside. Whether or not a company has made meaningful reductions to the labor force due to AI adoption, the fact is that the workforce feels this is a jobs problem. That is enough to make it a genuine issue we must keep front of mind.

Be specific about whose work you are talking about. The cleanup and roto category has already changed employment for assistant editors and junior VFX artists, and it did so before the current conversation started. That is a real thing that happened to real people, and it is different in kind from the speculative displacement that dominates the discourse. Conflating the two makes it easier for everyone to argue past each other.

I am not going to tell you what the right settlement is. I have not sat in those negotiations and I would be inventing a credential I do not have. What I will say is that the productions I would bet on are the ones where the question got asked out loud early, in front of the people affected, rather than resolved quietly at the vendor level and discovered in week six. Trust on a crew is a schedule asset. Losing it costs more than any tool saves.

A sociologist named Émile Durkheim studied and wrote extensively about the cataclysmic shifts that took place during the Industrial Revolution in the 19th century. He warned of the "malady of the infinite" among workers faced with the rapid escalation of technology, and not knowing where their lives would fit into all of it. From where I sit, that is exactly what I see many colleagues struggling with now, and at an exponentially faster pace. It is vital to all productions to engage with the emotional and rational concerns of our community, even if purely to ensure our proven, amazing workers give their projects the best work. There will be a future after an uncertain transition period. There was one for Durkheim's time, and there will be again.

Which brings me to the part nobody is arguing about yet.

The loss was not only hours. It was the ladder. During my time in unscripted and documentary post-production, I have watched the role of assistant editor go from one of learning, apprenticeship, and, yes, repetitive tasks to simply the repetitive tasks. It has become a rarity for me to be able to give a scene to an AE, offering a way to cut their teeth, grow, and make a name for themselves. That erosion happened slowly, it happened before this conversation started, and we let it.

We now find ourselves with the opportunity to change that. If these tools absorb the repetitive work, the hours they free up already belonged to junior people. We can reclaim those hours as savings, or we can give them back as scene work. That is a choice, and it is ours to make rather than the vendor's. Embracing tools that handle the simple tasks means we can give assistant editors and many other junior department members back the apprenticeship they have been losing.

It is incumbent upon all of us, as leaders and senior members of the media industry, to ensure that is how we utilize these tools: to build and steward our crafts and art.

What I would tell a team deciding this week

1. **Put generative tools upstream of commitment, not downstream of it.** Exploration, boards, temp, options. The value is in disposability. The moment the output has to be defensible, the economics invert.
2. **Label temp aggressively and control who sees it.** Assume any image an executive sees twice becomes an expectation. Build the labeling convention before the first review, not after the first misunderstanding.
3. **Budget the rebuild.** If generated material might reach final, carry the cost of making it conventionally as well. If you cannot carry that cost, you are not experimenting, you are gambling.
4. **Name one person accountable for provenance.** Where did this asset come from, what went into it, and can we clear it. If nobody owns that question, you will answer it under deadline pressure with incomplete information.
5. **Ask the crew before the vendor.** The people who will use the tool know within a week whether it works. That information is free and most productions do not collect it.
6. **When a tool absorbs a junior task, reassign the hours rather than reclaiming them.** The time these tools free up came out of somebody's apprenticeship. Decide deliberately where it goes, before the budget conversation decides for you.
7. **Re-evaluate every show.** These tools are changing fast enough that a conclusion from twelve months ago is not evidence. Neither is this document, in twelve months.

What I do not know

Whether the finishing objection holds. My confidence that generated material cannot currently survive an approval chain is based on countless days in the edit bay with executives and many more accounts from colleagues across the industry. It is a narrow sample, to be sure, and anecdotal, but it has yet to be

contradicted by tales of flawless success at picture lock and watchdown. I acknowledge that projects in other corners of our business may already have solved problems I have not seen solved.

Whether the drift problem is fundamental or temporary. It may be a tooling limitation that disappears in a year.

And whether the upstream-only recommendation is durable or just correct for right now. I suspect the latter, which is why I would rather publish a dated document that can be wrong than a set of principles that sounds permanent.

If you are running a show and your experience contradicts any of this, I would genuinely like to hear it. That is the more useful conversation and there are not enough people having it in public.

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